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World Health Organization

Cardiovascular diseases

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Overview | Symptoms | Treatment

Heart attack and stroke

Often, there are no symptoms of the underlying disease of the blood vessels. A heart attack or stroke may be the first sign of underlying disease. Symptoms of a heart attack include:

- pain or discomfort in the centre of the chest; and/or
- pain or discomfort in the arms, the left shoulder, elbows, jaw, or back.

In addition the person may experience difficulty in breathing or shortness of breath; nausea or vomiting; light-headedness or faintness; a cold sweat; and turning pale. Women are more likely than men to have shortness of breath, nausea, vomiting, and back or jaw pain.

The most common symptom of a stroke is sudden weakness of the face, arm, or leg, most often on one side of the body. Other symptoms include sudden onset of:

- numbness of the face, arm, or leg, especially on one side of the body;
- confusion, difficulty speaking or understanding speech;
- difficulty seeing with one or both eyes;
- difficulty walking, dizziness and/or loss of balance or coordination;
- severe headache with no known cause; and/or
- fainting or unconsciousness.

People experiencing these symptoms should seek medical care immediately.

Rheumatic heart disease

Symptoms of rheumatic heart disease include: shortness of breath, fatigue, irregular heartbeats, chest pain and fainting. Symptoms of rheumatic fever (which can cause rheumatic heart disease if not treated) include: fever, pain and swelling of the joints, nausea, stomach cramps and vomiting.

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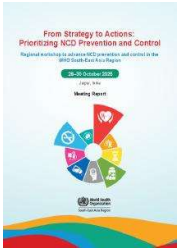

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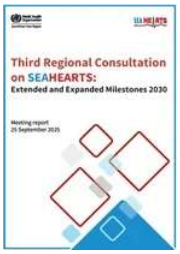

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